Horikita Suzune's Short Story: Contradiction?

(Original translation provided by Drago)

I CONTINUE THE conversation with Karuizawa-san regarding the topic of the alliance between Class C and Class D.

"Class D is a unique class. Seeing a wounded Class C, they might've sympathised with them. That being said, suddenly taking in a half-destroyed enemy is a difficult thing to do. Forming an alliance without prior coordination shouldn't have been easy..."

"That's true. Hirata-kun and the others were saying the same thing. They were deducing all sorts of things, like maybe they didn't only hand over the win but also private points."

When I mentioned that the contact between Ayanokouji-kun and Ichinose-san had happened early on, Karuizawa-san nodded strongly.

"I see... yeah, I think so too. Or rather, that's definitely it."

For me who'd be seeking certainty, her words served as a reassuring clincher.

With this, I feel more confident about being able to organise my thoughts a little and move forward.

Of course, there is no doubt that I have an additional seed of concern now, though.

"Hey... I know you dodged the question last time, but mind if I overstep and ask something a bit direct?"

She gazed at me with an expression that looked slightly hesitant, almost embarrassed.

"Hm, dodged? What are you talking about?"

Her reply to my question in return was—.

"Do you like Ayanokouji-kun, Horikita-san? Even in this situation where we've become enemies."

Along with those words, my thoughts almost came to a halt for an instant, but at the same time, I recalled an event from a little while ago. The trigger that brought Karuizawa-san and me closer, right after Ayanokouji-kun had transferred classes. The exchange on that bench.

"Eh? T-that's what you mean by overstep?"

"It's a pretty important matter to me, after all."

"D-didn't I tell you I've never fallen in love with anyone?"

Just like before, I denied it.

"But you're flustered."

"If you talk about whether I like someone or not, a topic that naturally flusters people, of course I'd react that way."

"Then do you like Sudou-kun?"

"Of course not. He's a dependable classmate."

"See, you answered instantly. Even though it's basically the same question."

"That's—"

That certainly might be strange.

There is no difference in the fact that Ayanokouji-kun and Sudou-kun are both high school boys.

And yet, a contradiction, however uncertain, is arising in my heart.

"If you're holding back out of consideration for me, you don't need to worry about it, 'kay."

Consideration? Does that mean something like it's okay if we fall for the same person?

No, in the first place, I don't even...

Before my thoughts could coalesce, Karuizawa-san continued.

"I don't think falling for the same person is a bad thing... Besides..."

As she was about to continue with 'Besides', her expression clouded for an instant.

"Besides... what?"

Curious about said expression she showed for just that instant, I instinctively asked back. However, to say that was the correct judgment might be a bit difficult—.

Morishita Ai's Short Story: Honour

(*Original translation provided by Drago*)

THE PAINTBALLS I fired with such magnificence were destined to hit every enemy, burying an army of thirty with a single gun, but as luck would have it, every single one missed. Even as I ran out of ammo and attempted to hurriedly remove the magazine, I was unable to swap it out successfully.

"This is a defective product, isn't it. At this point, practically speaking, there is no doubt about it."

In the midst of such trouble, it seems Class C showed their pathetic intention to retreat.

Located in the middle ranks, I also decided to begin falling back to avoid being hit.

However, it was at that moment. The opponent must have feared my very existence.

As almost all enemy gun barrels aimed for my frail back.

Normally, I would display movements as swift as Idaten, but due to various circumstances, that wasn't possible.

After only a brief respite, a merciless attack will surely pierce through me.

What must I do to save myself—.

As I fled desperately, what caught my eye was the tissue-paper-thin Yamamura Miki.

I cannot afford to fall here, which means there is only one option available to take.

"Look out, Yamamura Miki...!"

If I grab Yamamura Miki's shoulders and spin her around, she will turn into a shield.

As the entity who protected me, she'll be able to, however slight, leave behind some proof of her existence; in other words, we'll have a win-win relationship.

The moment I put strength into my grip on her shoulders to turn her into a shield, a sharp pain ran through my back.

"Ku...!"

An additional shot, then a second, followed by continued pain in my back.

"Uu...!"

"M-Morishita-san!"

It appears I was just slightly short on time to turn her into a shield...

"It appears... This is the end for me. At the very least, you run..."

"No way, why would you cover for someone like me...!"

"I still had a benevolent heart left in me; that is all. Live on, Yamamura Miki. And, in my place, as an Amazoness... *Slump*."

"Morishita-san... Morishita-san...!"

Well, I suppose this is fine too—.

As the person who risked her own life to cover for her, Yamaura Miki will likely be grateful towards me for the rest of her life.

And I can return to the ship and take it easy.

As a way to go out, it was truly an impeccable, honourable action, wasn't it. Period.

TL Notes:

Idaten: A reference to Skanda, a Buddhist guardian deity known for running very fast.

"Paper-thin": The raw text uses 薄葉紙 (thin paper/tracing paper) to describe Yamamura, referencing her character trait of having a very thin/weak presence.

Shiraishi Asuka's Short Story: Colourless and Transparent

(Original translation provided by Drago)

INSIDE THE TW0—PERSON TENT, for some reason, Hoashi-san was seizing before me.

"Please allow me to ask you a question!"

Saying so, she bowed her head deeply.

"You sure are acting awfully formal; just what is it that you might want to ask?"

"That is of course… whether there exists a person whom you are interested in, Shiraishi-san!"

I had thought she was acting strangely earlier, but I see, so that's what this is about.

Realising the reason behind Hoashi-san's distant attitude, I placed a hand on her shoulder.

"First thing's first, let's stop being so stiff, shall we? I much prefer your usual self, Hoashi-san."

"……I-is that so?"

Usually, she is an individual who treats everyone flatly. Her casual way of speaking, regardless of whether the other person is a boy or a girl, is her distinctive feature.

"Yes. Please act as you usually do."

"Well then… Yeah, got it. You see, it's just that I usually don't get to talk with you a lot, so."

Perhaps feeling a little more at ease, the quality of her voice distinctively changed. The tension loosened, and a genuine joy took the form of a voice, conveying a warmth that reached my way.

"Why is that? Please feel free to talk to me anytime."

"I mean, Nishikawa-san is always on guard. If I talk to you, she'll immediately cut in between us, right?"

"I think she simply wants to be included, you know."

"Hmm, doesn't look that way to me, though. Even earlier when it was decided I'd be in the same tent as you, she looked at me like I'd wronged her and she's holding a grudge."

Indeed, she—Ryoko-san—is an individual who directs a unique timbre toward me.

That is precisely why, I suppose, the people around her end up seeing us having a special kind of relationship.

"Well, never mind that. And, and...?"

Perhaps curious about my love life, she completely shelved the matter regarding Ryoko-san and leaned in eagerly.

"Well, yes, I am of course in love. I too am a high school girl in the throes of adolescence, after all. Would you want to know who it is?"

Nodding her head up and down vigorously, Hoashi-san's eyes sparkled.

"I like voices, regardless of whether they are men or women. So the person I'm drawn to is inevitably someone who possesses a very alluring voice... and just recently, I encountered a voice I thought was truly wonderful."

"That certainly narrows the suspects down... could that someone be sitting next to you in class?"

"Fufu. You sure are wicked, Hoashi-san. So you already largely had a mark on who it was, huh."

Just as I tried to continue the conversation, a sound of calm footsteps could be heard near the tent

Immediately after my brain recognised before I did that they belonged to Ayanokouji-kun's—

"There is something I want to ask of you, Shiraishi; do you have a moment?"

It was an entrance so perfect it was as though he'd timed it, wasn't it.

Lightly excusing myself to Hoashi-san, whose eyes were sparkling even more, I picked up a lantern and leaned out from the tent entrance.

"Good evening, Ayanokouji-kun. What is the matter?"

"I want to talk a little. Can you spare some time?"

"A talk... you say."

Though the late hour does weigh on my mind a bit, I wonder what this could be about.

The impression I hold of him, even now, is colourless and transparent. It is not easy to deduce what lies within based on the quality of his voice.

That is precisely what makes it so very alluring, though.

“Hey, hey. You'd better make sure other boys don't spot you, okay? It'd be a huge deal if you get caught, after all.”

Due to the contents of the conversation we were just having, her imagination too seems to be running wild.

Now, let's enjoy this little night date, shall we.

Shiina Hiyori's Short Story: Distancing

(*Original translation provided by Drago*)

THE MORNING SEA had been shining with a dazzling sparkle.

While gazing at that sea alone, I quietly let my thoughts wander.

What do I want to do from here on out? How must I proceed?

I want to cherish my time with Ayanokouji-kun.

However, choosing that might not lead the class in a positive direction.

"I am being greedy... aren't I."

Until a short while ago, I thought I might never be able to speak with Ayanokouji-kun again.

Even though I had been thinking that way, now that I have the time to do so, it has become a source of worry.

Since the Uninhabited Island exam began, Ruuen-kun has not asked me for advice even once.

Rather than saying I am not trusted...

It might be more accurate to say it feels like he is walking on eggshells around me.

Ryuun-kun knows how I feel.

Regarding that fact, I do not harbour any opinion of whether that's good or bad, but...

Surely, that is the cause of him keeping his distance.

"What is the right choice to make..."

I ask myself by putting it into words.

All that returns is the faint throbbing of my chest and the gentle sound of the waves.

"I want to see him... don't I."

I want to meet Ayanokouji-kun and talk.

My words and my heart repeatedly murmur the same thing.

We passed each other on the ship, but there was no opportunity to speak.

And speaking was not possible when we disembarked either.

Once the special exam is over, I will go to see him myself.

I resolved myself with a small bit of courage.

Even after that, I continue to walk quietly alone along the seaside.
While carving each step into my memory so as not to forget.

This daily life is by no means guaranteed—

Yes, one never knows when happiness will announce its end, after all—I walk on, strongly aware of that.